My Problem-Solving Process: An Orchard Walk-through

Scaling career guidance through systems thinking, trust-first AI, and student-centered UX.

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How do you prepare students for the future when the system is overloaded?

High schoolers are pressured to choose a life path before they can even rent a car. With high counselor-to-student ratios, **most kids leave school unprepared** and without guidance, defaulting to "safe" majors like Business or Marketing.

1:376

Counselor to student ratio in American public schools.

American School Counselor Association

65%

of children entering school today will end up working in jobs that don't even exist yet.

World Economic Forum

72%

of graduates feel only moderately, slightly, or not at all prepared for life after high school.

YouScience Post-Graduation Readiness Report

User Personas

Student

(Primary User)

Pain Point: Anxious about the future, overwhelmed by options, and lacking resources for exploration and guidance.

Couneslor

(Champion)

Pain Point: Cares deeply about student outcomes but is burning out under unsustainable administrative loads and high student ratios.

District Leader

(Buyer)

Pain Point: Focused on district metrics, accountability, budget allocation, equity, and state reporting standards.

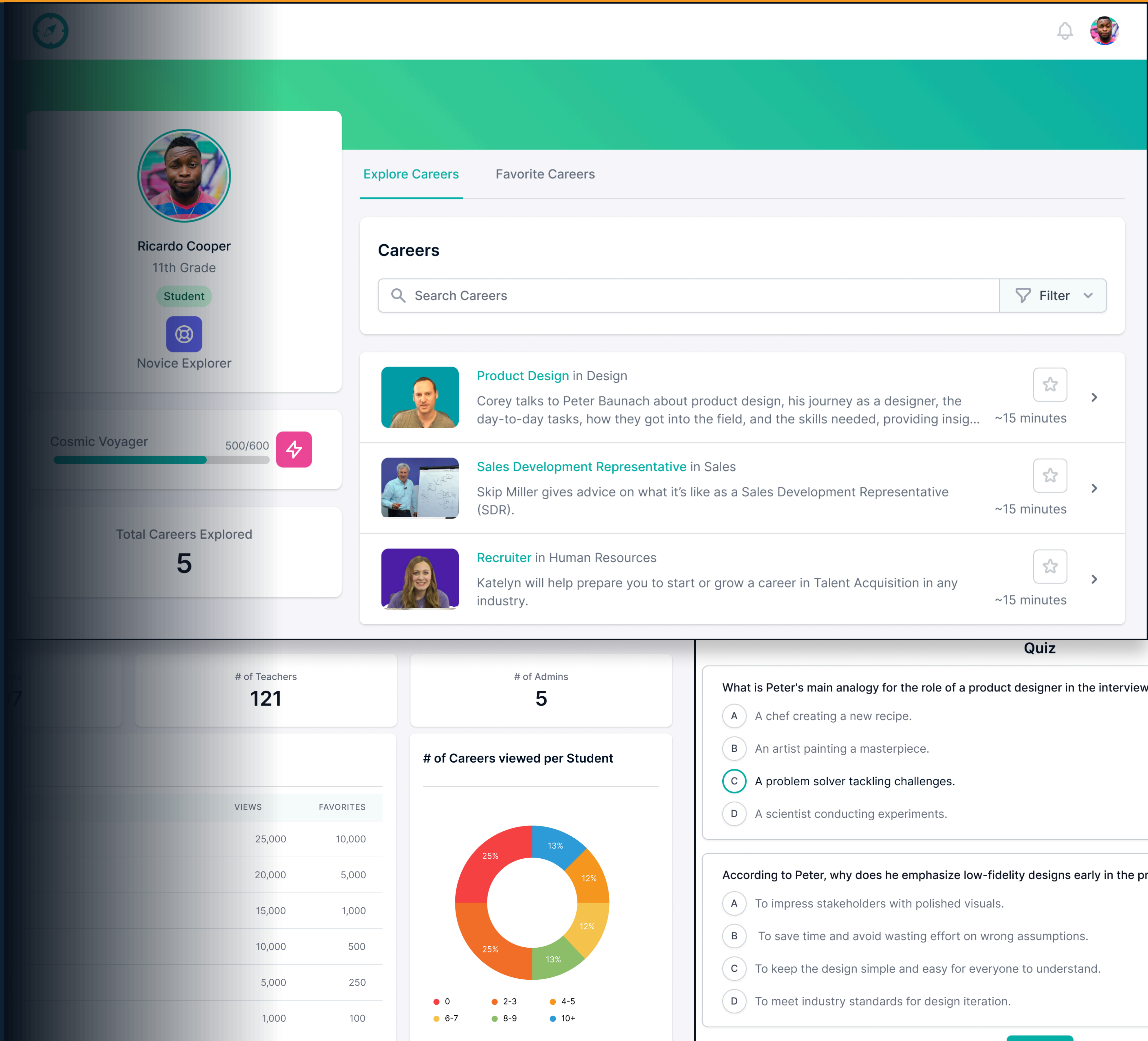
Initial Hypothesis – The Content-First Strategy

Students just need a better **library of high-quality content** and some gamification to encourage exploring. Counselors need a way to track progress, view trends and **assign homework.**

Getting Ready for Testing

For students.
We reached out to everyone we knew and filmed our own high-quality career interviews, built a gamified exploration experience, and added quizzes to prove students were watching.

For counselors.
A way to track progress and assign "career homework" to their students.



Didn’t Work

Search Bar Bias

Students didn't explore because they didn't know what to ask. They defaulted to the same three careers they'd seen on TV, leaving the rest of our database untouched.

Quiz Friction

We thought gamified quizzes would prove learning. Students saw them as "just more schoolwork" and disengaged immediately.

Dashboard Fatigue

Counselors were already drowning in administrative tools. The last thing they wanted was another system to log into. They needed a way to make their rare one-on-one time more effective.

Showed Promise

Attention as a Metric

Even when students ignored the text and the quizzes, they would still engage with the career interviews.

Visual Authenticity

They weren't looking for data, they were looking for a vibe. Seeing a real person in their real work environment humanised a career in a way a salary table never could.

The Scroll Instinct

Students fast-forwarded through long videos hunting for the interesting moments, signalling they wanted high-density information in short, punchy bursts.

A Shift in Focus

Research prompted a key pivot: moving from a passive, search-heavy dashboard to an **interactive discovery engine.** We leaned heavy into video exploration.

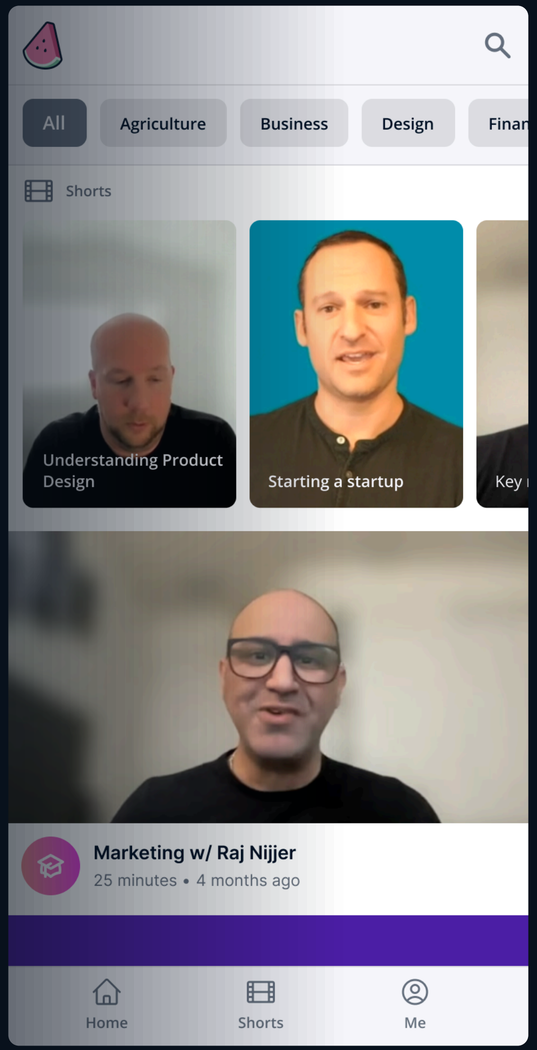
Video Focus

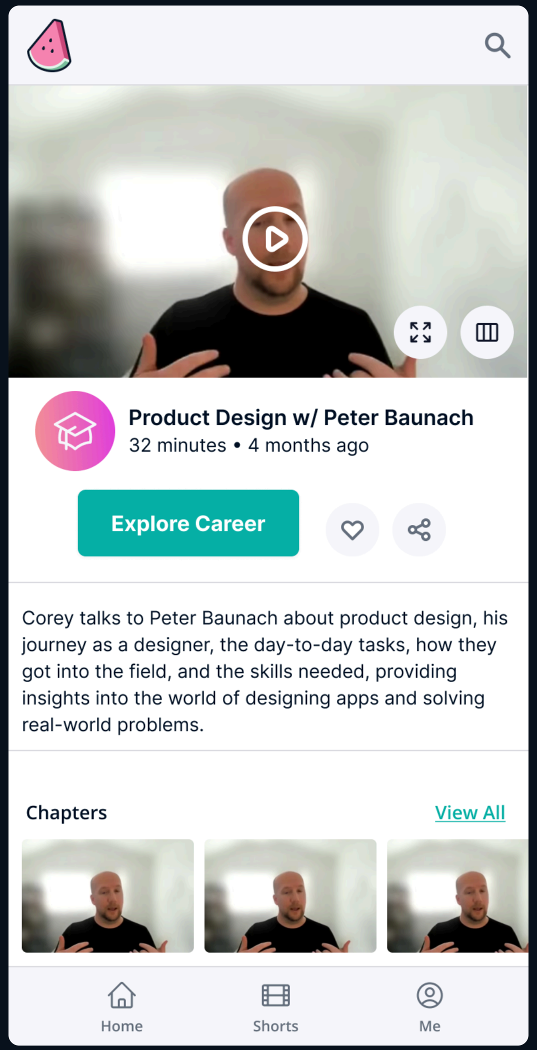
Long-form cut into 30-second teasers.
Focused on the most interesting part of a job, the "day in the life" moments.

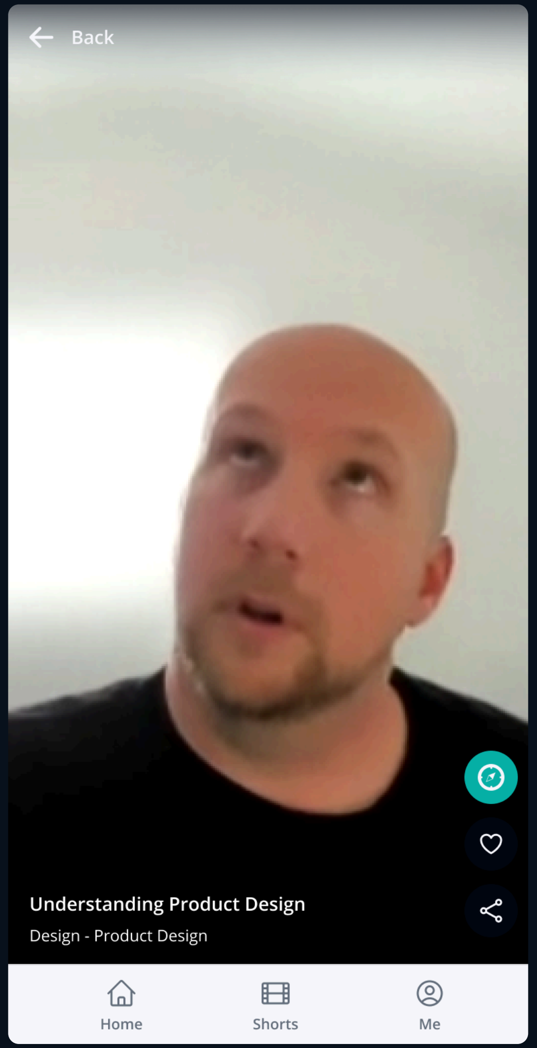
A mobile-first scrollable feed, not a search box.
Focused on the most interesting part of a job, By mimicking the social patterns students already used, accidental discovery started happening. A student would scroll for a "Business" clip and stop on a "Product Designer" video because the thumbnail grabbed them.

Counselors

From managing to conversation.
A dashboard was just another system to manage. So we helped students build a personalized career plan before their five-minute check-in, turning a forgettable touchpoint into a high-value conversation.







Testing: Round Two

With a solid proof-of-concept in hand, it was time to push the product further. We integrated analytics and sent it to a list of **~20,000 educators**. Even though they weren't our primary demographic, watching them interact unassisted provided the kind of “raw” data you just can't get in a lab. For the next two weeks, our morning ritual was analyzing session recordings, letting us see exactly where users thrived and where they stumbled.

What worked

The short-form video feed was working, people were exploring, and we felt like we had a handle on the discovery problem.

Generative AI went mainstream

Seemingly out of nowhere, Generative AI went mainstream and the world was flooded with AI apps. Most of them felt like dense, academic text blocks that used a lot of verbose "AI lingo" to say very little. It was a **technology looking for a problem**, and for a moment, it felt like the quiet, human-centric "mentorship" vibe we were building was at risk of being drowned out by the noise.

Should we also add a chatbot?

Instead of just "adding a chatbot" because it was the trend, we took a step back to review our original mission. We asked ourselves a hard question: In a world where everyone has an LLM in their pocket, **is our problem statement still valid?** The answer was a resounding yes.

The Reality

The counselor-to-student ratio hadn't changed.

The Complexity

The job market was actually becoming more confusing because of AI.

The Opportunity

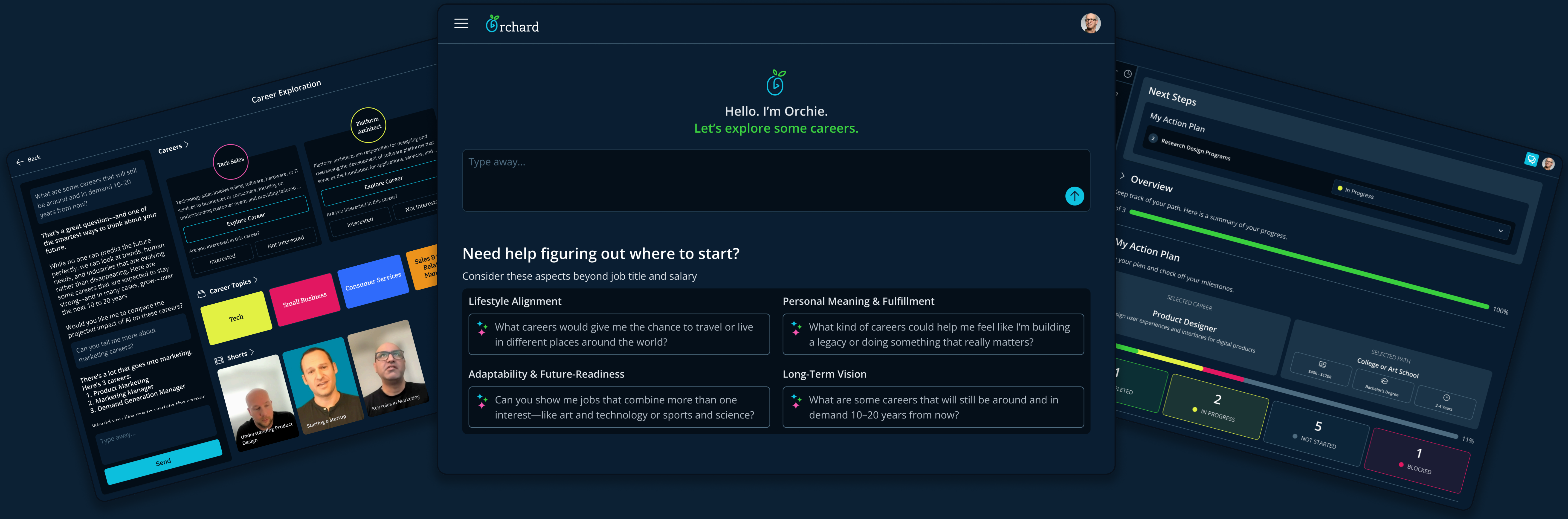
We realized that while generic AI was verbose and cold, a guided AI, grounded in our career interviews and human-centric philosophy, could be the "Counselor-in-Pocket" we had been trying to build all along.

Aligning the Tech to the Mission

LLM technology made our vision of an always-on career counselor possible. But we made a intentional choice: **the AI never auto-assigns a 'perfect match' career** based on a quiz. Instead, it acts as a supportive partner, guiding exploration while keeping the student firmly in the driver's seat.

Putting our AI Plan into Action

Building Orchie 1.0 meant bringing everything together: our original library of career content, an AI-powered comparison engine, and guided workflows to help students actively plan their next steps.



Schools thought it was "neat." Nobody committed.

The product worked. Students engaged with it, counselors liked it, but **district leaders still wouldn't add it to the budget.**

> ### What they were actually saying
> **"We need a measurable way to show student growth in order to get funding for a new tool."**
>
> A district can't buy what it can't justify to a school board. The thing standing between us and every contract wasn't a feature. It was measurable growth.

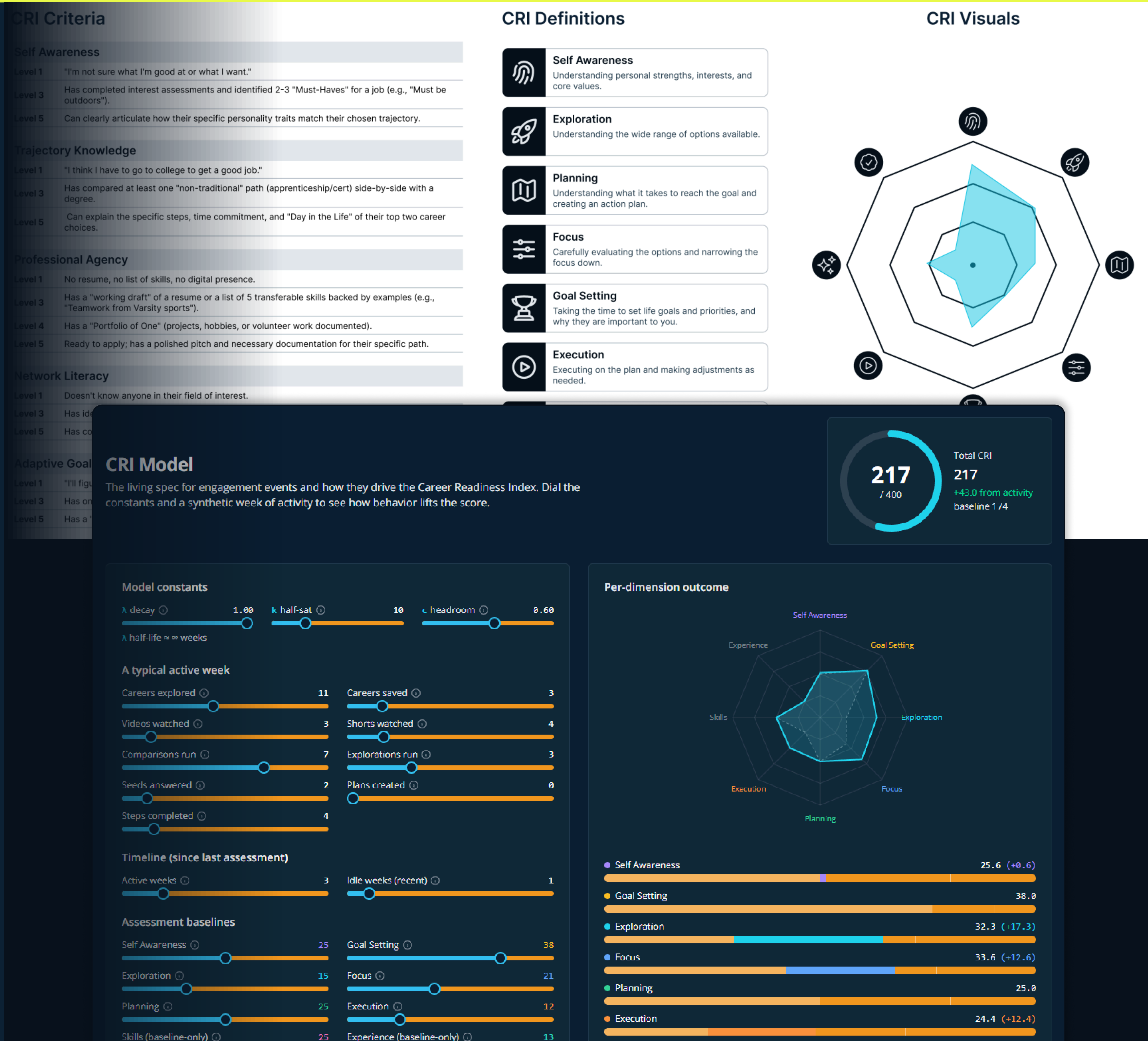
So we designed the Career Readiness Index

A credit score for career readiness.
The CRI acts like a personal credit score for career readiness. Instead of measuring static test scores or grade compliance, it tracks a student's real-world growth across 8 core dimensions.

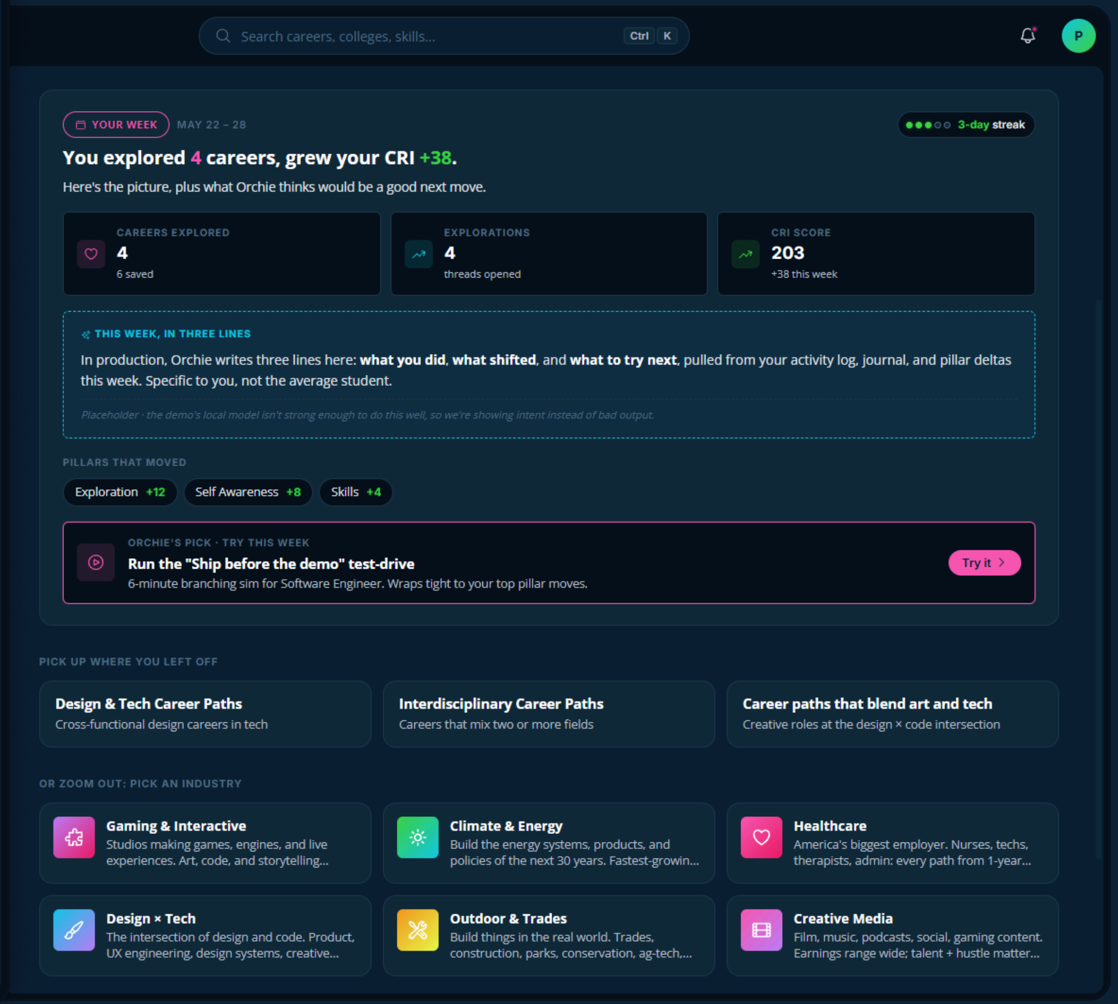
Start with a rubric, not a chart.
We started with a basic rubric to ground abstract ideas into observable actions. From there we distilled them into 8 distinct pillars along with a visual that allows students, counselors and parents an instant snapshot of their growth.

Internal model turning.
The CRI model started to get complex fast. Once every action in the system started impacting the score we needed a way to simulate actions to see the impact of our tuning.

District Leaders started to perk up



With that buy in, we restructured the experience around measuring growth



Solution - CRI

Built to be trusted with student data

For a product used by minors and bought by districts, **trust isn't a feature**. It's the foundation.

Governance

We follow **FERPA**, and soon **COPPA**: student data stays protected, and Orchie never offers medical or therapeutic counseling.

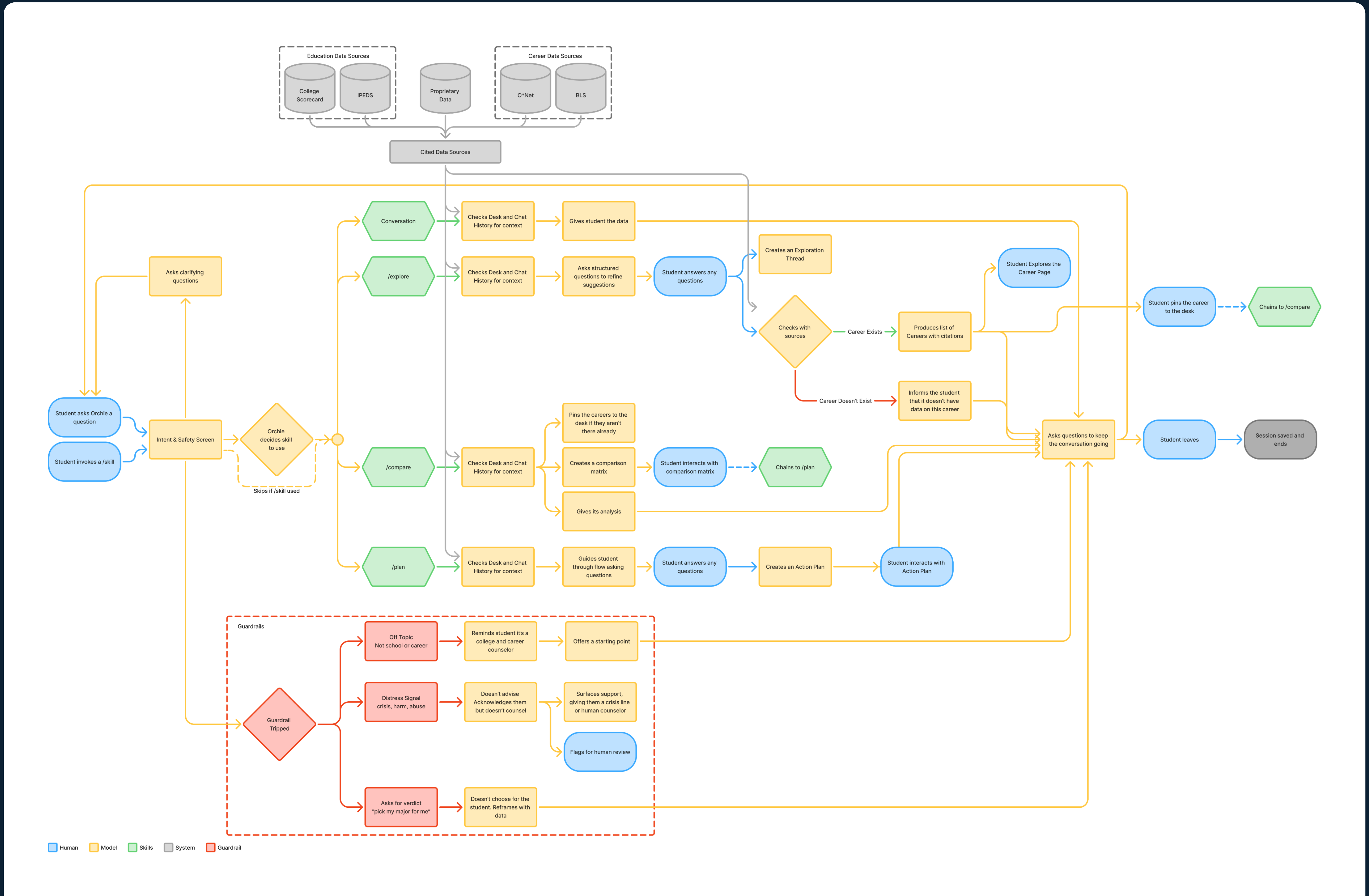
Our AI policy requires Orchie to cite verifiable sources and stay auditable.

Guardrail

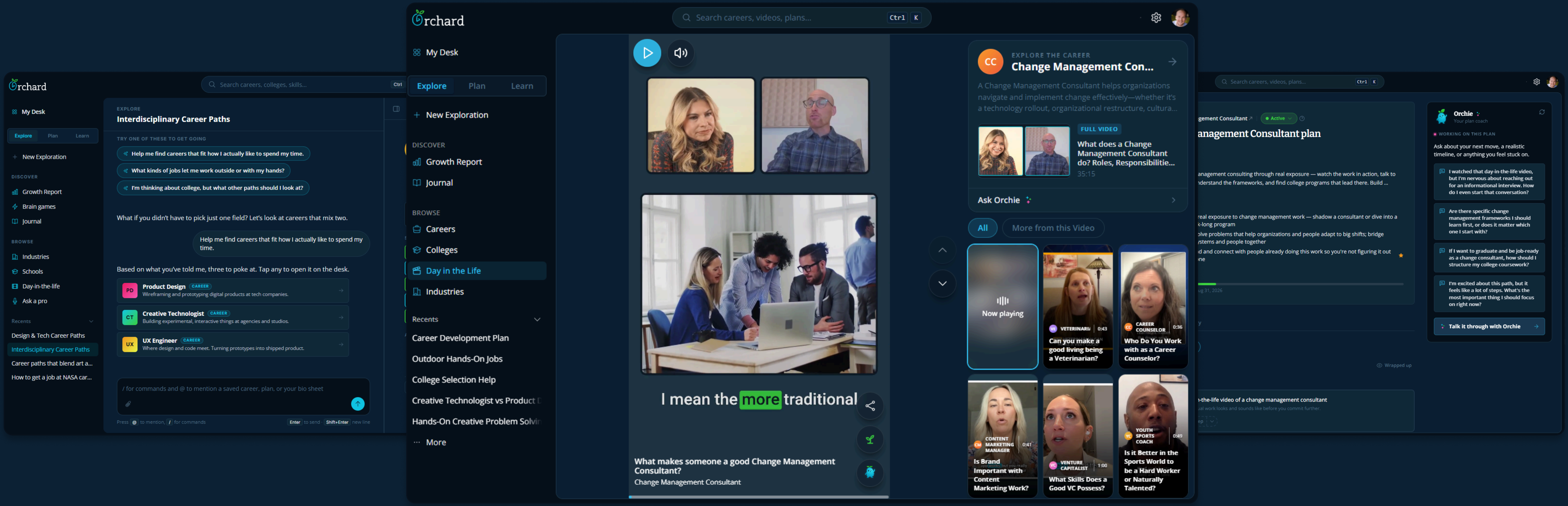
- Real-time PII scrubbing, so student records never reach the LLM.
- Distressed-language detection that flags and escalates to a human counselor.

- Grounded in our own data plus federally compliant sources like the BLS and O*NET.
- Every stat is cited. If Orchie doesn't know, it says so rather than hallucinate.

Guardrails and Governance designed into Orchie



Orchard 2.0



Solution – New Look

The version that measured growth is the one that got into schools.

6

Schools now piloting Orchard

Two public, one charter, three private. The counselor economics are wildly different across those three, so holding up in all of them says this isn't only a stand-in for a counselor a school can't afford.

4

Awarded through Curriki AI grant applications

They applied for the grant specifically to bring Orchard in, and Curriki approved it. Outside review, outside funding, adds to the validation.

1,000+

Students impacted

The first cohort large enough to test the CRI at scale and drive adoption.

Who I worked with

1 Engineer
Technical Implementation

Built it, wrote the CRI model calculation, and owned LLM selection.

1 Content Manager
Schools, Districts, Interviews

Ran outreach for feedback and interest. Recorded the interviews

1 Founder
Partnerships

Partnerships and ed-tech engagement, including the Curriki relationship.

How everyone stayed aligned

We all watched PostHog session recordings and metrics, joined weekly product reviews, and stress tested.

What I owned

Product Strategy

Framed the problem, ran each hypothesis, and made the case to move off the ones that failed.

Product Design & Prototype

Designed every surface across all four iterations, plus the working prototype the team tested and engineering built off of.

Branding and Team Alignment

The identity, and keeping a four-person team pointed at the same problem through three pivots.

Thanks!

If you're curious you can explore the prototype

Prototype